

managerial positions.

Srividya Kannan, Founder and Director of Bengaluru-based digital solutions firm Avaali Solutions, cites the highly competitive and demanding nature of tech-sector jobs, topped up with a culture and work environment that makes it difficult for women to balance work and family life, as some of the reasons behind the drop in women's participation in senior management roles. That apart, "One of the critical challenges is the pervasive gender bias and discrimination that still exists in the workplace, especially in the tech sector," she says.

Token Measures

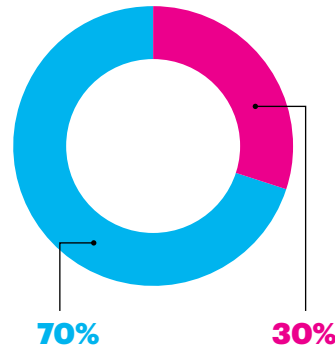
While tech firms have taken some steps to improve the diversity of their workforce in a bid to improve women's representation, Madhushree Dutta, Head of HR at cloud services firm Pure Storage India, explains that token representation will not make much of a difference. "The changes have to be systemic. Token representation just to show diversity and inclusivity on paper will not make a difference," she says, adding that women employees need to be nurtured from early on in their careers. "They need to be shown how their growth can play out in a company."

Another challenging aspect of the gender gap is the drop in the number of women in science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM)-focussed roles compared to the number of women graduating from STEM-focussed courses. Data from World Bank shows that women make up nearly 43 per cent of the total STEM graduates in India, but account for only 14 per cent of all scientists, engineers and technologists.

A Marginal Increase

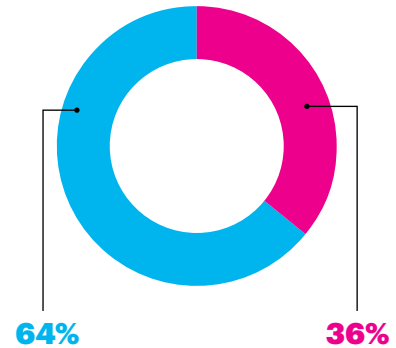
► Women's participation in tech has gone up marginally in the past decade

2012-13



► This is despite corporate initiatives to improve gender participation and better opportunities

2022-23



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Dutta says that corporates and policymakers need to deploy robust measures to ensure that women in STEM roles are supported and retained from the early stages of their careers. "The drop from colleges to corporate shows that there is a need to improve retention of women in the industry. We need to narrow down the prob-

lem, why are women dropping off?" she asks. "If it's about a lack of opportunities, then we need to give them a clearly defined career path. If it's because of work-life balance, we need to support them as they address the issue. Support from the company is critical to bring any positive changes."

But the gender gap is not just



Robust measures are needed to ensure women in STEM roles are supported early in their careers